DATA COLONIALISM

In the sixteenth century, when Spanish, Portuguese and Dutch conquistadors were building the first global empires in history, they came with sailing ships, horses and gunpowder. When the British, Russians and Japanese made their bids for hegemony in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, they relied on steamships, locomotives and machine guns. In the twenty-first century, to dominate a colony, you no longer need to send in the gunboats. You need to take out the data. A few corporations or governments harvesting the world's data could transform the rest of the globe into data colonies – territories they control not with overt military force but with information.[14]

Imagine a situation – in twenty years, say – when somebody in Beijing or San Francisco possesses the entire personal history of every politician, journalist, colonel and CEO in your country: every text they ever sent, every web search they ever made, every illness they suffered, every sexual encounter they enjoyed, every joke they told, every bribe they took. Would you still be living in an independent country, or would you now be living in a data colony? What happens when your country finds itself utterly dependent on digital infrastructures and AI-powered systems over which it has no effective control?

Such a situation can lead to a new kind of data colonialism in which control of data is used to dominate faraway colonies. Mastery of AI and data could also give the new empires control of people's attention. As we have already discussed, in the 2010s American social media giants like Facebook and YouTube upended the politics of distant countries like Myanmar and Brazil in pursuit of profit. Future digital empires may do something similar for political interests.

Fears of psychological warfare, data colonialism and loss of control over their cyberspace have led many countries to already block what they see as dangerous apps. China has banned Facebook, YouTube and many other Western social media apps and websites. Russia has banned almost all Western social media apps as well as some Chinese ones. In 2020, India banned TikTok, WeChat and numerous other Chinese apps on the grounds that they were 'prejudicial to sovereignty and integrity of India, defense of India, security of state and public order'.[15] The United States has been debating whether to ban TikTok – concerned that the app might be serving